Weekday Scheduling Desk

500 interviews a day, two interns, one playbook

At about 19:51 every evening, 500 interview requests land from 100 partners. By 19:51 the next day, Weekday has promised that 400 of them will be in a calendar. Nobody can be called before 10:00, and the people making the calls are two college interns.

I built the desk they work from. Along the way, the arithmetic turned up something more useful than the desk: no amount of hustle gets two interns to 80% by phone. This document is the playbook, the proof and what I would do about the gap.

500	14h	~210	49%
requests every evening, from 100 partners	of the 24-hour window when no one can be called	calls two interns can make before the deadline	interns' ceiling: every call books and settles all that person's requests

The problem: Capacity. 426 people sit behind the 500 requests, and two interns get about 210 tries. Even if every call booked and settled all of that person's requests, interns would book at most 49%.
What I built: A sheet where interns make no judgement calls: a ranked list, a WhatsApp message already typed, one log line per conversation. On a simulated day, every mechanics check passes.

What I need: Partner’s written OK to book on their calendars, WhatsApp opt-in collected when candidates say yes, and openness to resetting the target if the data says 80% can't be bought.

THE JOB:

Candidates have already agreed to interview. The only thing between that yes and an interview is a booking and the brief is to get one for 80% of requests within a day.

- **Input**: about 500 requests a day from 100 partners, each with the partner's Calendly link.
- **Output**: 80% booked within 24 hours of arriving, by call, WhatsApp or email. The interview itself can be later.
- **Product**: a to-do sheet two college interns can follow almost blindly, in a world where candidates miss calls, ignore email, skip WhatsApp, or agree and then forget.
- **Bonus**: fewer than 5% no-shows on either side.

Why it matters? At my planning values two interns schedule about 45% of requests (224 of 500), 176 short of the 400 target. Each scheduled interview is worth about Rs 8,100 to Weekday (Rs 18 lakh CTC x 15% fee x 3% hire rate). A request that misses 24 hours isn't automatically lost, since many are still interviewed later.

In a scenario where a quarter of them never are, the gap puts about Rs 3.6 lakh of expected fee value at risk a day (176 x 25% x Rs 8,100). The upper case of the same scenario, where no late request is ever interviewed, is Rs 14.3 lakh. Neither is a measured loss: both also assume the 3% hire rate holds for these marginal requests and each hire pays the full fee. The 25% is my least certain input, and the first to replace with Weekday's data.

7 QUESTIONS I'D ASK BEFORE BUILDING ANYTHING

Question	My assumption	What it changes
When do requests arrive?	As one evening batch, around 19:51.	The deadline is 19:51 the next day, and 14 of the 24 hours fall outside contact hours. The real window is under 10 hours.
Where are the candidates?	India, on IST. Contact only between 10:00 and 21:00.	No night calls. Without an evening message, the batch sits untouched until 10:00.
What counts as scheduled?	Only a time in the partner's calendar. A sent link never counts.	Keeps the number honest. Counting "said yes" would inflate first-try success from 40% to 45%.
Can we book for candidates?	Only where the partner agreed in writing	Where we can, a call ends in a booking. Where we can't, it ends in a link and a follow-up.
Are 500 requests 500 people?	No. About 426 people, 1.17 requests each, and about 4% of rows are re-sent duplicates.	Call people, not requests. Dialling per request would waste one call in seven.
When do the interns work, and how fast?	Ram 10:00-18:00, Shyam 12:00-20:00. About 4.5 minutes per try.	Sets capacity at about 210 tries. Minutes per try is the first thing measured live.
Is the data clean?	No. Broken emails, short phone numbers, missing IDs.	The sheet flags bad rows up front, so interns don't find them mid-call.

THE REAL PROBLEM IS CAPACITY, NOT PROCESS

The arithmetic, for one evening batch	Value	Kind of number
People behind 500 unique requests	~426	Demo data
Intern minutes before the 19:51 deadline (Ram 10:00-18:00, Shyam 12:00-19:51)	951	Arithmetic
Tries two interns can make, at 4.5 minutes each	~210	Arithmetic
Share of requests they could book even if every single try booked	~42/49%	Arithmetic
Realistic: 40% of first tries book, fewer later; 25% of requests book with no call	~45%	Planning estimate

Every share in this document is a share of the 500 unique requests. Every estimate also uses one assumption set: the planning rates above, and 1.17 requests settled per successful call (the batch average; the simulated day settled 1.15). On that basis interns can book at most 49% even if every call books. The outer bounds are 42% if each call settled only one request and 56% if calls reached the people with the most requests first and settled them all; the simulated day sat at the average. Requests booked without any call sit on top, so 80% needs at least 31% of requests booked with no call, more interns, or both. tests/model_consistency.py rebuilds these from the raw batch.

So the design question changes. It is no longer "how do we chase everyone?" but two sharper ones: who gets the 210 calls, and how do we get candidates to book without a call at all?

It is also why the desk doesn't work first-in, first-out. When 500 requests arrive in the same minute, FIFO is just a random order. The list is ranked by how likely a call is to book and how close the deadline is

“So what. Every design choice that follows serves one of those two questions.”

SIX JOBS, EACH WITH EXACTLY ONE OWNER

#	Job	Owner	Where it lives
1	Receive and check	Lead	INPUT: paste the partner's rows. Each gets an ID (R001, R002, ...) that follows it to the booking. Duplicates and bad contacts are flagged.
2	Prioritise	Sheet	DESK: one row per person, ranked by chance of booking and time left.
3	Contact	Intern	RAM / SHYAM: call, then book or send the WhatsApp that's already typed.
4	Follow up	Sheet	The person returns after a fixed wait with the next message, up to 3 tries.
5	Confirm	Intern	LOG: one line per conversation. Only BOOKED or SELF_BOOKED counts.
6	Close and learn	Lead	DASHBOARD: why each request was or wasn't scheduled, and each assumption next to what the log measured.

THREE WAYS TO CLOSE THE GAP AND WHY I'D START WITH THE CHEAPEST

	Model 1: Call desk	Model 2: Nudge, then call	Model 3: More interns
What it is	Two interns work a ranked list by phone and WhatsApp.	Model 1, plus a provider WhatsApp at ~20:00. YES replies jump the queue.	Model 1 with 5-6 interns.
Ready on day 1?	Yes. The sheet is built for it.	No. Needs opt-in, a provider and approved templates.	No. Needs hiring and training.
Reaches 80%?	No. Capped near 49%.	Unknown. About 60% if 40% of candidates then book alone.	Only if second and third calls book almost as well as first calls.
Extra cost per day	None (two stipends, ~Rs 1,800).	Rs 100-750 in message fees.	~Rs 900 per extra intern.
Load on interns	Low: one list, one log.	Same as Model 1.	Same, split more ways.

Decision: Start with Model 1, because it works tomorrow and produces the measurements the other two depend on. Pilot Model 2 on days 3-5. Decide on Model 3 on day 6, with measured numbers rather than my guesses.

“So what. Model 1 isn't the answer to 80%. It's the instrument that tells us which answer is.”

ONE REQUEST'S JOURNEY:

Before the rules, here is a single request moving through the desk.

A WORKED EXAMPLE (ILLUSTRATIVE)

Mon 19:51. Partner 017 sends Diya K. for Round 2. Diya also has a Round 1 request from Partner 042. The sheet gives them IDs R118 and R377 and puts Diya on one row, because one call covers both.

Tue 10:00. Diya ranks near the top: two open requests, a Round 2, and Diya opened Weekday's earlier email. Ram calls. No answer. Ram sends the typed WhatsApp and logs NO_ANSWER.

Tue 12:05. Two hours later the sheet brings Diya back, now on Shyam's list, with the try-2 message. Diya picks up. Partner 017 lets us book, so Shyam books Wednesday 16:00 on the call and logs BOOKED for R118. Partner 042 wants its own link, so Shyam sends it and logs SENT_LINK for R377.

Tue 15:05. R377 returns with "your interview isn't booked yet". Diya has already booked. Shyam logs SELF_BOOKED.

Result: Two requests, three tries, both scheduled in under 20 hours. The link alone was never counted.

Step 1. Receive and check (lead, evening)

- The lead pastes the partner's sheet into INPUT. Every row gets an ID that follows it to the booking.
- Duplicates (same email, company, round and interviewer) are removed, and the earliest copy keeps the 24-hour clock.
- Bad contacts (no @ and dot in the email, or a phone that isn't 10 digits) leave the list, and the lead asks the partner.
- New partners get their link in PARTNERS. "We may book for candidates?" is YES only with written agreement.

Step 2. Prioritise (the sheet)

- One row per person, all their open requests together.
- Rank rises with open requests and the chance a try books; x1.3 for Round 2 or 3 (warmer, and they block the partner's pipeline); x2 with 4 hours or less left (row turns yellow); x5 for a YES reply to the evening WhatsApp.
- While both interns are on shift, people are split by phone number, so nobody is called twice.

Step 3. First try (intern, from 10:00)

- Picks up, partner lets us book: book the first free slot on the call. BOOKED.
- Picks up, partner wants its link: send the WhatsApp with the link. SENT_LINK, which is not a booking.
- No answer: send the WhatsApp anyway, so they have the details. NO_ANSWER.

Step 4. Follow up (the sheet brings them back)

- NO_ANSWER or CALL_BACK: back after 2 hours, with "again about your interview", then "last reminder".
- SENT_LINK: back after 3 hours with "your interview isn't booked yet".
- Three tries, then off the list. Never outside 10:00-21:00.

Step 5. Confirm

- Only a BOOKED or SELF_BOOKED line counts. A line with no ID covers all the person's open requests.
- Late reply or call-back: the intern types the phone in the yellow box on their tab and sees what to book.

Step 6. Close the day (lead, after the deadline)

- Every request ends in exactly one state: scheduled in 24h, scheduled late, not interested, stopped, bad contact, partner has no slots, or missed (never tried / tried, not booked / link sent, never booked).
- Partners with full calendars get an email, and their requests pause until the lead types REOPENED.

WHAT RAM AND SHYAM ACTUALLY DO: (FOUR STEPS, ALL DAY)

Interns don't read playbooks; they read row 1. So the playbook fits on the START HERE tab, and every rule that needs judgement lives in a formula instead.

The loop

1. Open your tab (RAM or SHYAM) and start at row 1.
2. Do what column G says. Click Call. Then book, or click WhatsApp and press send.
3. Log it. One line in LOG: time (Ctrl+Shift+;), your name, the phone, the outcome. Add a request ID only if the answer is about one of their requests.
4. Go back. The finished row disappears and the next one moves up.

The day

Time	Ram	Shyam
10:00	Start. You have everyone until noon.	-
12:00	The list splits automatically. Keep going from row 1.	Start at row 1 of SHYAM.
18:00	Done for the day.	You now have everyone.
20:00	-	Done for the day.
Anytime	Call-back: type their phone in the yellow box. Unsure: write it in Notes and ask the lead.	Same.

Nine outcomes

Outcome	When	Comes back
NO_ANSWER	Called, no answer. You sent the WhatsApp.	After 2 hours
CALL_BACK	They picked up but asked you to call later.	After 2 hours
BOOKED	You booked it for them in the partner's calendar.	Done
SENT_LINK	They said yes; you sent the partner's link. Not a booking.	After 3 hours, to check
SELF_BOOKED	They had already booked it themselves.	Done
NOT_INTERESTED	They no longer want this interview.	Done
STOP	They asked us to stop contacting them.	Never
WRONG_NUMBER	Wrong number, or not their WhatsApp.	Never
NO_SLOTS	The partner's calendar is full. Write the request ID.	When the lead reopens

Four nevers

- Never contact anyone before 10:00 or after 21:00.
- Never promise anything about the job, the salary, or a held slot.
- Never book in a partner's calendar unless column G says to.
- Never edit any tab except LOG.

CALL TO GET AN ANSWER; WHATSAPP TO LEAVE A TRAIL

Each channel has one job. A call gets an answer now, and an answer is what books an interview inside 24 hours. A WhatsApp makes sure that even a missed call leaves the details on the candidate's phone.

- Phone first, every try.
- WhatsApp after every call, answered or not. Pre-typed with the name, the company and, where needed, the link. The intern only presses send.
- Email: left out of version 1. Calendly already sends the confirmation email, and a 500-email blast is unlikely to be read inside 24 hours. If WhatsApp delivery turns out poor, an email nudge is the first addition.
- Evening WhatsApp (pilot): sent around 20:00 the night requests arrive, to use the 14 dead hours. Candidates can book, or reply YES and wake up to a call.

When	Text (name, company and link filled in by the sheet)
Try 1	Hi {name}, it's {intern} from Weekday. You have an interview request from {company}. ...
Try 2	Hi {name}, {intern} from Weekday again about your {company} interview. ...
Try 3	Hi {name}, last reminder from Weekday about your {company} interview. ...
Check after a link	Hi {name}, your {company} interview isn't booked yet. ...
Ending, we may book	Reply YES and I'll book the first free slot.
Ending, partner's link	Pick a time: {link}
Evening template A / B	Hi {name}, Weekday here. You have an interview request from {company}. Reply YES and we'll book the first free slot for you / Pick a time: {link}. Reply STOP to opt out.

NO-SHOWS: DESIGNED NOT YET BUILT

A booking only pays when both people turn up. The sheet stops at the booking today; this is how I'd carry it to the interview.

- **Day before**: WhatsApp to the candidate with the time in IST and a CONFIRM / RESCHEDULE reply. No reply by 18:00 goes on the next day's call list.
- **One hour before**: WhatsApp to the candidate, email to the interviewer.
- **Five minutes in**: the intern calls whichever side hasn't joined. This needs a join signal from the meeting tool or the interviewer; without one, interns call candidates for interviews inside working hours.
- **Afterwards**: the partner marks show or no-show, so the under-5% target is measured, not assumed. Repeat no-shows are flagged on the candidate's profile.

FIVE NUMBERS DECIDE EVERYTHING

The dashboard tracks more, but these five settle whether 80% is reachable and what it costs. Each planning assumption sits next to its measured value, and the model switches to the measured one as soon as there's enough data.

1. Scheduled within 24h, as a share of unique requests. The headline. Target 80%.
2. Booking rate by try number. If tries 2 and 3 book far less than try 1, extra interns buy little. The most important number in this document.
3. Minutes per try. Sets capacity. Measured by timing 20 real tries on day 1.
4. Share that book with no call. The lever the evening WhatsApp is meant to move.
5. Why requests weren't scheduled. Never tried is a staffing problem; tried and not booked is a message problem; link sent and never booked is a friction problem. Each has a different fix.

NOT WITH TWO INTERNS AND MAYBE NOT WITH SIX

The table shows the share scheduled within 24 hours under different assumptions, from the arithmetic in analysis/scenarios.py. The first three columns are the unknowns the first live days will measure.

Book with no call	Try 1 books	Later tries keep	2 interns	4 interns	6 interns	Best case	Interns for 80%
25%	40%	100%	45%	65%	82%	82%	6
25%	40%	70%	45%	62%	72%	72%	never
25%	40%	40%	45%	58%	63%	63%	never
40%	40%	100%	60%	80%	86%	86%	5
40%	40%	70%	60%	74%	78%	78%	never
40%	40%	40%	60%	69%	71%	71%	never

How to read it. 80% needs second and third tries to work almost as well as first tries, plus 5-6 interns. If later tries lose even a third of their pull, the best case is 72-78% however many people are hired. My expectation is that they do lose pull, so the likely outcome is a conversation about the target, backed by measured numbers.

Is hiring at least cheap? Yes. A try costs about Rs 9 of intern time, and the extra tries a new intern buys mostly reach people with one request each. At Rs 8,100 per scheduled interview, an extra try pays for itself if 1 in about 940 books, and still if 1 in 209 does at a 1% hire rate and Rs 12 lakh CTC. Extra interns are a safe bet on cost. Whether they get to 80% is the open question.

If the data says 80% is out of reach: (a) agree a KPI on the measured best case, for example 80% of reachable candidates, or 80% within 48 hours; (b) fix it upstream, by re-confirming interest before a request is sent and getting slot guarantees from partners; (c) keep whatever extra capacity pays for itself. With no extra staff at all, the list still spends every call on the likeliest booking and the nearest deadline.

“So what. Under my assumptions the gap puts about Rs 3.3 lakh of expected fees at risk a day, with Rs 13.2 lakh as the upper case..”

What would change my mind

- Tries 2 and 3 book almost as well as try 1: hiring works, on the model's assumptions: about 6

interns reach 80% if 25% of requests book with no call.

- 40% book with no call and later tries hold up: about 5 interns reach 80%, and every booking the message wins is cheaper than a call.
- Later tries lose a third of their pull or more: no headcount gets there. The conversation is about the target and the upstream fixes.